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Culture (OWC): [Luguru \(FN32\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1959-1960

Coverage Date: 1959 AD - 1960 AD

Place Coverage

Uluguru Mountains, Morogoro Region, Tanzania

Section Title(S): JOKING AND PRIVILEGED FAMILIARITY

It is also permissible to appropriate the possessions of watani, but rather definite rules govern this type of acquisition. For one thing, it should be done openly and in the presence of the owner or his family. Confiscation is most likely to occur at a funeral when watani of the deceased may walk off with a goat, fowl, yams, or even such items as a hoe or panga. If a mtani saw three hoes by a house, he might say "You have too many hoes" and take one. Again, this is always done in a joking manner; the owner may not seriously object, and it is part of the expected routine or ritual at a burial. At time of death in the clan some Luguru have been known to move their livestock to another hamlet and hide items that might catch the eye of the acquisitive mtani.

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Watani are also permitted to appropriate meat or produce being carried uncovered, and leaves or a branch should be placed over a headload of vegetables. An elder should never carry a load on his head, covered or not, for if he meets a mtani he risks confiscation; thus a youngster should accompany him if there is a load to carry. Also eligible for appropriation by watani is clothing with a ragged hem or ragged edge exposed, as is clothing turned inside out when it is placed out on the ground, a bush, or roof of a hut to dry. The right to confiscate such garments is said to be associated with, or derive from, the function and role of watani at the time of burial, which will be discussed below. A cheap grade of cotton cloth, known locally as *Amerikani*, is used to make this shroud or *sanda*, which is a crudely and hurriedly constructed sack. Watani may take anything carried in a bag resembling a sanda, or clothing that is unhemmed or has rough edges exposed. Garments laid out on the ground or on a bush are said to resemble a corpse, thus becoming fair game for watani.

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In cases where a mtani sequesters produce or belongings, he should spit on them first, which indicates he is taking them because they are improperly carried, worn, or displayed. An interesting aspect of acculturation has occurred regarding the right of watani to take clothing placed out to dry. If it is hung on a clothesline, a trait borrowed from the European, it should not be taken even though it is turned inside-out.

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However, property seized under these conditions is rarely retained permanently. While it would be legally permissible to do so, it is expected that it will be returned to the original owner after payment of a small sum, usually a fraction of a shilling, as ransom.

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While most property is taken as a form of joking, a Luguru may go to a mtani and request food because of a special need such as a required ceremony. He may ask for a goat or grain, and discussion will ensue as to whether or not  1319 he can pay for it, but he should not be refused. While he may agree to pay later, in all probability he will not compensate the owner. This is not cause for serious concern, as the procedure will be reversed at some future date. Luguru informants could not recall a case where a man had used his privilege as a mtani to acquire wealth he did not need or take advantage of the situation. It would definitely be considered anti-social behavior, and reciprocal action by watani would soon discourage such an unseemly practice.

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